

The Unpreserved Bodies

Most of the dozens of skeletons were killed by the usual suspects of childhood abuse and neglect. Malnutrition and starvation, throttling, blunt trauma, stabbing, shooting, sexual violation: the bones tell stories of every sadistic thing a depraved adult can do to a small victim. And who knows what else? You could barely tell what was going on in that folder. The bones are an eternal reminder that no matter what, you *couldn't* get there early enough.

The Preserved Bodies

Eleven of the bodies are mysteriously well preserved. No embalming took place, yet certain children appear mummified, retaining skin and desiccated organs long after the flesh should have rotted away. Nothing in the geological survey of the graves indicates how the bodies escaped the ravages of time. Many have been found in wet pits that should have long ago liquefied all flesh. The chalk-eyed, shrunken rictus smile of small corpses remind you that if you had been just a little earlier you could have saved more of them.

The earliest preserved body died sometime in the mid-1690s, which is long enough ago that the body should have rotted to bones. The artificial fabrics tag in one of the clothes lists a manufacturing date. You know for a fact that this is what this kid had on his tiny body when they took him from his parents, and you'll never be able to return him back.

The leathery tissues of the body are inexplicably sterile. No microbiological cultures of any kind can be found among the dead cells. No bacteria. No mold. No decomposer of any kind. Not even scavenger animals wanted anything to do with these bodies. Those monsters did.

In every preserved body, the cause of death appears to be an extreme case of Alzheimer's or some similarly advanced stage of cognitive decay. The brain, though dry and difficult to examine, exhibits signs of widespread glial scarring. It is reminiscent of chronic traumatic encephalopathy (CTE), but their skulls contain no hairline fractures or other signs of trauma. Furthermore, the scale of the damage is beyond anything you have ever seen. It went deep enough to affect autonomic processes such as eating, swallowing, and breathing. The children died because something made them forget how to live. You thought you could forget about what you failed to prevent in a mere fifteen years. You can *NEVER* bury the past.